## 7.2 IOs, Public Opinion, and Social Media

Historically, IOs have relied on government intermediaries, traditional media outlets, and elite networks to disseminate data, policy advice, and messaging to audiences like academics, policymakers, and subject-matter experts. In the past decade, however, IOs have embraced social media platforms like Twitter and Facebook, bolstering their ability to reach broad, transnational audiences quickly and cost-effectively. These platforms also enable citizens to engage directly with IO messaging, fostering discussions and debates online (Gil de Zúñiga, Koc Michalska, and Römmele 2020).

Among social media platforms, Twitter/X has emerged as the most prominent for IOs (Twiplomacy 2017). Its microblogging format provides a powerful avenue for IOs to communicate directly with domestic audiences, bypassing national governments and traditional media filters. Importantly, citizens don't need to follow IO accounts explicitly to see their content—retweets, promoted posts, and trending topics often extend the reach of IO messages to a broader audience. While Twitter is far from the only place IOs seek public engagement—the World Bank now has a TikTok account—its broad use by IOs makes it attractive for empirical study.

Although citizens may pay little attention to IO social media feeds during routine periods (Guisinger and Saunders 2017; Brutger and Clark 2022), their engagement spikes during times of crisis or heightened salience. For instance, IOs like the WHO became globally prominent during the COVID-19 pandemic, while the IMF gains visibility when countries undertake controversial loan programs. Similarly, populist critiques often amplify IO salience by linking them to politically charged issues, such as when the WTO faced heightened attention after the United States levied heavy tariffs on China under the Trump administration. These moments are particularly significant, as public opinion tends to exert the greatest influence on policymaking during times of crisis (Bailey 2003; Verdier 1994).

Public opinion during these critical junctures, as well as during more business-as-usual periods, is critical to IO legitimacy and effectiveness (Dellmuth and Tallberg 2023). Recognizing this, IOs actively seek to enhance their visibility and favorability among domestic audiences. They do so in several ways, including claiming relevance on salient issues—for instance, the IMF's recent foray into climate change, which has increased its